

VOLCANIC ERUPTIONS

VOLCANO NAME	DATE	DESCRIPTION
Vesuvius (southern Italy)	79	Destroyed cities of Pompeii and Herculaneum
Oraefajökull (Iceland)	1362	“Glacier burst” devastated coastal communities and covered northern Iceland in ash
Mount Etna (Sicily)	1669	Worst eruption in modern times, destroying a dozen villages
Lanzarote (Canary Islands)	1730–36	Longest recorded eruption in the Canary Islands, burying communities in the west
Laki (Iceland)	1783	Produced largest flow of lava ever recorded
Tambora, Sumbawa, (Indonesia)	1815	Effects of volcanic ash aerosol caused the “year without a summer” and crop failures and famines in many countries
Krakatoa (Indonesia)	1883	Caused much of island of Krakatoa to sink, killing 35,000 people. The volcanic aerosol produced beautiful sunsets worldwide for several months
Montagne Pelée (Martinique)	1902	Destroyed the town of Saint-Pierre.
Mount St. Helens (Washington State)	1980	Destroyed 185 miles (300 km) of roads.
Nevada del Ruiz (Colombia)	1985	Mud flow destroyed town of Magdalena, killing 23,000 people.
Pinatubo (Philippines)	1991	Expelled 10 times as much material as Mount St. Helens, but mass evacuations meant only 200–300 people died.
Eyjafjallajökull (Iceland)	2010	Volcanic ash cloud grounded aviation in much of Europe

FLOODS

COUNTRY	DATE	DESCRIPTION
England	48	Flooding of Thames River caused 10,000 deaths
England and Netherlands coastline	1099	Severe winter storm caused floods that killed 100,000 and created the Goodwin Sands
Netherlands and Germany	1218	North Sea storm surge killed 100,000
Belgium, Netherlands, Denmark	1287	Severe storms caused floods, killing 50–80,000
Denmark, Netherlands, northern Germany	1362	Widespread coastal floods killed 100,000
Western England	1606	Tsunami in the Bristol Channel killed 3,000
China	1887	Floods along the Yellow River broke dikes, drowning 900,000
Central China	1931	Flooding of Yellow, Yangtze, and Huai rivers killed up to 3,000,000
Guatemala	1949	Hurricane caused floods, killing 40,000
Bangladesh	1974	Heavy monsoon rains caused floods, killing 29,000
China	1975	Failure of the Banqiao Dam, Henan Province, led to floods and deaths of 86,000; worst dam failure in history
Pakistan	2010	Floods submerged one-fifth of the country, killing 2,000
Australia	2010–11	River surges killed 35 and devastated several towns in Queensland

FAMINES

PLACE	DATE	DESCRIPTION
Central America	c. 800–900	Drought and famine caused collapse of Classic Maya civilization
China	875–884	Famine sparked the Huang Zhao rebellion, which fatally undermined the Tang dynasty
Japan	1229–32	The Kangi famine, worst in Japanese history
Northern Europe	1315–17	“The Great Famine” killed up to 10 percent of the population (partly through effects of disease on a weakened population)
India	1406–17	The Durga Devi famine in Maharashtra killed many thousands over a 12-year period
Russia	1601–03	Worst famine in Russian history, killed up to 2 million – one third of the population
India	1630–32	Severe famine in the Deccan led to around 2 million deaths
Prussia	1708–11	Famine killed 250,000 (around two-fifths of the population)
Bengal, India	1769–73	Worst famine in Indian history killed 10 million
Ireland	1845–49	Potato blight caused severe famine and death of 1 million
Iran	1870–71	“The Great Persian Famine” killed 1.5 million and led to many nomadic tribes becoming sedentary
Ethiopia	1888–92	“The Great Ethiopian Famine”; pest killed 90 percent of cattle; locust and caterpillar plagues ate most crops; one-third of population perished
Ukraine	1932–33	The “Holodomor”; Soviet collectivization and industrialization policies caused famine that killed 4 million
China	1959–61	“The Great China Famine”, the worst in Chinese history, killed 30 million
Ethiopia	1984–85	Failure of rains caused famine, killing up to 1 million

EPIDEMICS AND PLAGUES

PLACE	DATE	DESCRIPTION
Greece	430–427 BCE	Early description of plague symptoms during epidemic at Athens
Mediterranean world	165–180	The Antonine Plague killed up to 5 million, one-third of the population of the Roman Empire, severely weakening the military might of the Roman army
Mediterranean world	541–542	Plague of Justinian killed 40 percent or more of population
Worldwide	1348–50	The Black Death killed around 30 million people
India	1817	First recorded outbreak of cholera in Bengal
India	1907	Outbreak of bubonic plague killed 1.5 million
India	1630–32	Severe famine in the Deccan led to around 2 million deaths
Worldwide	1918–19	Spanish influenza killed 50 million, the worst recorded natural disaster